

Problems and Prospects of Culinary Tourism in Kerala

SYNOPSIS SUBMITTED TO SRINIVAS UNIVERSITY FOR THE DEGREE OF

DOCTOR OF PHILOSOPHY IN TRAVEL AND TOURISM MANAGEMENT

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1. Introduction

Culinary tourism is the focus on food as an attraction for exploration and a destination for tourism. Although food has always been a part of hospitality services for tourists, it was not emphasized by the tourism industry until the late 1990s. It now includes a variety of formats and products – culinary trails, cooking classes, restaurants, farm weekends, cookbooks, food guides, and new or adapted recipes, dishes, and even ingredients. While most culinary tourism focuses on the experience of dining and tasting of new foods as a commercial enterprise, it is also an educational initiative channelling curiosity about food into learning through it about the culture of a particular cuisine, the people involved in producing and preparing it, the food system enabling access to those foods, and the potential contribution of tourists to sustainability. This paper focuses upon the fact that food tourism is a very sustainable way of establishing new career opportunities in any region, which also give recognition to the local cuisine

2. Literature Review

Morten Boesen, Donna Sundbo & Jon Sundbo (2017): The study had investigated the question that why local food networks succeed or fail in collaborating with local tourism. The article had focused on entrepreneurial local food networks and their collaboration with local tourism. The study had

emphasized on the actions and attitude logics of local food networks and tourism and whether their respective logics fit as a factor to explain why or why not development of local food concepts lead to increased local tourism.

Tommy Andersson & Lena Mossberg (2017):

The study had addressed about the need for more awareness and knowledge about the growing number of food tourists. The basic objective was to describe the effects of enduring food involvement on consumer behavior with regard to food consumption and travel. The study had suggested five proposals about involvement having effects on consumers' identities, attitudes, motivations and travel behavior and all were supporting the feedback taken for the survey. The research had practical implications about the destination management organizations and restaurants, as well as tourism attractions serving food, cannot ignore that a large segment of the urban population is highly involved in food. There were many good reasons to serve food that satisfies normal criteria for maintainable food, which is healthy and locally produced

Travel Age West (2017):

The article reports that according to World Food Travel Association's (WFTA) "2016 Food Travel Monitor Report," several American leisure travelers consider culinary activity to be motivation for visiting destination. Topics include Munch, a limited-edition, culinary-focused product launched by travel firm Contiki, views of Toni Ambler, global brand strategy director for Contiki, on how food serves as the original social networking experience and people engaged in food or beverage experience.

Yogesh Updhyay & Dhiraj Sharma (2014):

The study had explored culinary preferences of foreign tourists through surveys conducted at various tourist spots in India, in order to identify dormant factors. The outcome of the research had suggested that tourists preferences converge into five factors i.e. taste and quality of food, food preparation, localization of food and dining etiquettes, tradition and nutrition of food, and food aroma and cleanliness. Additionally, convergence in foreign tourists was also explored on the basis of their responses. From the analysis, three segments were identified i.e. taste seekers, localization seekers and experience seekers. The study also had discussed the implications of the outcome for marketers and researchers.

Anne-Mette Hjalager & Pia Johansen (2013) :

The study had investigated the feasibility of combining environmental protection and

agricultural revitalisation strategy which includes food tourism in couple of national parks. The study had identified governance opportunities that could accommodate the well- being of both tourists and food producers, which had required a proactive role from the national park authorities, especially in marketing and development of event

Shahrim Ab Karim & Christina Geng-Qing Chi. (2010):

The study illustrates the food image of countries like France, Italy, etc. which are known for their popular cuisine. The outcomes revealed that in general, Italy had the most favourable food image and the highest potential to be visited in the future, a significant positive relationships was found between food image and visit objectives. The study also had confirmed that traveller's purchase decisions were significantly influenced by different types of information sources, the information would be principally useful for destinations interested in promoting culinary tourism.

Joan C. Henderson (2009):

The purpose of the paper was to review the contribution of food to tourism with reference to importance of food tourism and the factors which are critical to its success. The study suggests that Food is the subject of various types of tourism product and is a common theme in marketing, by businesses and by destination authorities. Tourism in which food plays a primary or supporting role is already popular and has good prospects, but there are also challenges for the food and tourism industries to overcome, which may vary from destination to destination. The study reveals the opportunities that were suggested as well as problems to be resolved by suppliers and marketers if the potential of food tourism is to be fully exploited.

Everett. S, & Aitchison. C (2008):

The study had examined the role of food tourism in developing and sustaining regional identities within the context of rural regeneration, agricultural diversification and the creation of closer relationships between production and consumption in the countryside. The primary focus was on rural development issues pertaining to increasing tourism impacts and identityThe study also had enhancement of environmental awareness and sustainability, an increase in social and cultural benefits celebrating the production of local food and the conservation of traditionalheritage, skills and ways of life. The research also had appealed attention with regard to three major issues: the role of food tourism in increasing tourist spending, the potential role of food tourism in extending the tourist season, and the re- examination of food tourist typologies within a

sustainability framework

Bob McKercher, Fevzi Okumus & Bendegul Okumus (2008) :

The study had examined that whether food is a special interest or mainstream tourism product. The study had contend that a more complete approach is required to inspect food tourism within the context of other products in the destination to determine its worth. The study had suggests that consuming food may be a permeating activity for most visitors to sophisticated urban destinations and may not be representative of a specialist segment.

G. E Du. Rand, & E Heath (2006) :

The study had developed a framework and guidelines for developing and implementing food tourism, as this would enable destination marketers and entrepreneurs to optimise the tourism potential of local and regional food. To support the food tourism destination marketing framework the researcher had developed a couple of keys that would provide the stakeholders with a mechanisms to develop and implement food tourism. The study outlines the key components and an evaluation of the framework and tools that have been developed. However the guidelines and recommendations for the development, packaging and marketing of local and regional foods are postulated.

Lucy Long (2004):

A culinary tourist differs from a normal or a traditional leisure tourist in so far as they do not have to leave their country or even their home; due to the fact that it is not only about eating, but also about exploring other aspects of the food system, a culinary tourist can also be a person who watches cooking shows or reads cooking books which offer mental journeys to other food worlds.

Priscilla Boniface (2003) :

The author had proposed that a destination wanting to attract Culinary tourists should consider several relevant points, the most important amongst them being to identify itself and the product clearly, to decide whether diversion or alteration of products is necessary to cater to the target market and to assess how the necessary dialogue and connection with the consumer can be made.

Everett, S. (2019):

The study had examined the role of gastronomic landscapes in shaping tourist experiences. It had emphasized that culinary tourism must be rooted in place-based resources such as

regional cuisines, local farming practices and food rituals. The research had highlighted that inconsistency in quality, lack of standardized food trails and weak stakeholder engagement remain major obstacles for developing regions. The study also had suggested that destinations with strong cultural narratives achieve higher visitor satisfaction.

Sánchez-Cañizares, Sandra & Castillo-Canalejo, Ana (2015):

The study had investigated tourist motivations for participating in gastronomic experiences. It had identified five key drivers: authenticity, cultural immersion, novelty, social interaction and learning. The research had revealed that tourists increasingly prefer experiential dining events and local culinary storytelling. The findings had stressed that destinations lacking structured food tourism products face challenges in converting culinary interest into actual visitation.

Tikkanen, Irma (2007):

The study had conceptualized the consumption of local food as part of the tourism experience cycle. It had analysed how tourists evaluate food products before, during and after their trip. The study had found that positive evaluations of local cuisine significantly influence destination loyalty. The research also had stressed that local governments need to promote hygiene standards, culinary diversity and food authenticity to strengthen food tourism competitiveness.

Molinero, Ruth, García, Jaime & Barroso, Manuel (2022):

The study had explored how digital media shapes culinary tourism choices. It had revealed that social media platforms play a significant role in influencing food-related decisions, particularly among younger tourists. The research had emphasized that destinations must invest in digital storytelling showcasing local foods, chefs and food heritage. The study also had identified challenges such as inconsistent branding and poor digital presence of local vendors.

Lin, Yi-Chin et al. (2011):

The study had evaluated destination food image and its impact on tourist satisfaction. It had indicated that tourists associate food image with freshness, hygiene, taste, service quality and authenticity. The findings had pointed out that food image strongly influences destination recommendation behaviour. The study had concluded that improving food hygiene and presentation standards can significantly enhance culinary tourism potential.

Cohen, Erik & Avieli, Nir (2004):

The study had examined the cultural dimensions of local food consumption and tourist satisfaction. It had highlighted that tourists sometimes hesitate to try local foods due to perceived risk, hygiene concerns and unfamiliar cooking methods. The research had recommended that destinations should provide safe culinary environments, food explanations, and demonstrations to increase acceptance of regional cuisines. The study is particularly relevant to regions promoting unique indigenous foods.

Berno, Tania (2011):

The study had analysed the relationship between food tourism and sustainability. It had emphasized that culinary tourism can support environmental sustainability when local ingredients are prioritised. However, the research had pointed out issues such as supply chain gaps, over-commercialization, and cultural dilution. The study had highlighted the significance of training local chefs and promoting farm-based experiences to enhance sustainability.

Fields, Kevin (2002):

The study had identified four motivations for food tourism: physical, cultural, interpersonal and status. It had stressed that food is no longer a secondary attraction but a primary motivation for travel among certain tourist segments. The research had found that destinations must develop varied culinary offerings — from street food to gourmet experiences — to appeal to a wider audience.

Quan, Shun & Wang, Ning (2004):

The study had discussed peak and supporting experiences in tourism consumption. It had classified food experiences as both peak experiences (unique, memorable meals) and supporting experiences (daily consumption). The research had emphasized that to maximize tourist satisfaction, destinations must ensure consistent quality of both everyday food and signature culinary events. The study had identified gaps in food service infrastructure in many developing tourism destinations.

Hjalager, Anne-Mette (2010):

The study had presented a comprehensive typology of food tourism trends, including organic food tourism, experiential food learning, culinary festivals and local food networks. It had stressed that food tourism evolves through innovation and consumer interest in authenticity. The study had revealed that destinations lacking coordination, innovation and training often struggle to position themselves as gastronomic hubs.

Keller, Peter & Bieger, Thomas (2003):

The study had analysed how competitive destinations build strong identities through cultural products such as cuisine. It had emphasized the need for strategic planning, food branding and public-private partnerships. The research had noted that fragmented culinary supply chains and inconsistent marketing strategies hinder the growth of culinary tourism in several regions.

Richards, Greg (2015):

The study had explored the role of creativity in food-based tourism experiences. It had revealed that tourists increasingly seek hands-on activities such as cooking classes, food trails, chef tables and interactive dining. The research had suggested that creative food experiences enhance destination appeal. It also had highlighted barriers such as lack of innovation, limited trained chefs and inadequate culinary infrastructure

Hall, C. Michael & Sharples, Liz (2008):

The study had examined the evolving relationship between food, regional identity and tourism development. It had explored how culinary resources can be strategically used to position destinations globally. The authors had highlighted that culinary tourism strengthens regional branding, enhances authenticity and contributes to sustainable development when linked effectively with local producers. The study also had emphasized that poor stakeholder coordination and limited policy support often hinder the full realization of culinary tourism potential.

Kivela, Jakša & Crofts, John (2006):

The research had analysed gastronomic tourism as a behavioural phenomenon and investigated why tourists choose destinations based on food experiences. The study had revealed that food acts as a cultural symbol and that tourists increasingly seek destinations that provide authentic local cuisines. It had concluded that destinations with strong food identities attract repeat visitors. The findings also had stressed the need for quality assurance, hygiene, food storytelling and cultural immersion to create appealing culinary tourism products.

Bessière, Jacinthe (2013):

The study had focused on local food heritage as a driver for territorial development. It had identified how food heritage contributes to community well-being, regional pride and socio-economic opportunities. The research had emphasized that the success of food tourism depends on community participation, preservation of culinary traditions and coherent

branding strategies. The article also had highlighted challenges such as commercialization, dilution of authenticity and insufficient training for food tourism entrepreneurs.

Sims, Rebecca (2009):

This study had explored the consumer quest for ‘authentic’ local foods and how destinations respond to these expectations. It had suggested that tourists view local food as a means of connecting with place, culture and people. The study had argued that while local food strengthens rural economies, tensions arise between mass tourism demand and the supply capacity of small producers. The findings had implications for regions like Kerala where small-scale food producers dominate.

Horng, Jeou-Shyan & Tsai, Chen-Tsai (2012):

The study had examined how culinary marketing strategies enhance destination competitiveness. It had proposed a model linking culinary resources, branding, innovation and tourist satisfaction. The authors had revealed that destinations promoting culinary festivals, food trails, and social media storytelling attract higher tourist engagement. The study also had recommended professional training for food handlers and collaboration between tourism boards and local chefs.

Okumus, Fevzi (2020):

The study had investigated food tourism innovation and sustainable practices adopted by destinations. The research had identified several emerging trends such as farm-to-table experiences, culinary heritage preservation, and wellness-based cuisine. It had emphasized that destinations must overcome challenges such as lack of certification, inconsistent food quality and skill gaps among culinary entrepreneurs. The study also had highlighted the importance of gastronomic mapping and digital promotion.

Ellis, Andrew et al. (2018):

The article had presented a comprehensive review of gastronomic tourism and identified four conceptual pillars: motivations, experiences, products and impacts. The study had emphasized that food tourism contributes significantly to local economies but requires alignment of food safety, authenticity and destination image. It had highlighted the gap between tourist expectations and actual food infrastructure in several developing regions – a finding relevant for Kerala’s context.

Smith, Stephen & Xiao, Honggen (2008):

The study had examined food as an attraction and its contribution to destination

competitiveness. The research had identified that tourists perceive food not only as a necessity but also as a major experiential component. The article had stressed that destinations must provide unique culinary narratives and improve collaboration between restaurants, farmers and tourism agencies. The study also had noted operational problems such as inconsistent standards, limited menu innovation and seasonal constraints

3. Need and Significance of the Study

The study would become significant as it concentrates on identifying prospects and problems of Culinary Tourism in Kerala. It is useful for the Culinary Tourism entrepreneurs to plan and execute Culinary Tourism products and services according to the expectations of the tourist. It enables Kerala tourism department to adopt Culinary Tourism entrepreneur centred approach to solve current problems in Kerala Culinary Tourism. Like any other value-added venture, the Tourism industry in Kerala has many problems as well as expectations. Kerala still has a lot of opportunities to exploit in the Culinary Tourism business. The study is helpful to formulate strategies and solve present problems of Kerala Culinary Tourism

4. RESEARCH GAP

Majority of the Culinary Tourism related studies have been conducted in Europe.No Prior study has been undertaken regarding the problem and prospectus of culinary tourism in Kerala

5. Specific Research Questions

- (1) What are the situational analyses of the current scenario of Kerala Culinary Tourism?
- (2) Is the concept of Culinary Tourism fully understood by the Culinary Tourism stakeholders in Kerala?
- (3) What are the problems of Culinary Tourism in Kerala that prevent the development of Culinary Tourism in Kerala?
- (4) What are the prospects of the Culinary Tourism business in Kerala?

6. Objectives

To find out the barriers that prevents the development of Culinary Tourism in Kerala.

The research objectives derived from the research questions:

1. To conduct situational analyses based on the current scenario of Culinary Tourism
2. To provide a conceptual clarity for Kerala Culinary Tourism

3. To identify problems of Culinary Tourism in Kerala that prevent the development of Culinary Tourism in Kerala
4. To outline the prospects of Culinary Tourism business in Kerala

7. Research Methodology

The Research adopted to carry out the present study is scientifically derived in view of the research questions and objectives. Quantitative and qualitative method is adopted for this study. Researcher conducted SWOT analysis to understand the current scenario of culinary tourism in Kerala. Qualitative methodology is used to identify the problems and prospects of Culinary Tourism in Kerala. The target population of the study is culinary tourism stakeholders in Kerala. Data were collected through in-depth interviews using structured questions to address research questions. After the transcription of interviews, the data so was collected through in search of specific words or meanings that were significant to the topic and coded. The words (keywords) were then extracted and gathered. From the keywords, categories were identified. The answers were then interconnected to the groups as well as the research questions. From the conclusions, themes were developed to answer the research problem and objectives.

8. Chapterisation of the study:

Chapter 1: This introductory chapter provides a brief discussion regarding Culinary tourism in Kerala. The chapter gives an insight into the research problem, statement of problem, scope of the study, significance of the study, research questions, objectives, limitation of the study and chapter scheme.

Chapter 2: This chapter reviews literature related to the topic. It includes meaning and definitions of culinary tourism, literatures on Culinary tourism in global perspective, in India, and in Kerala. Researcher collected data through several prevailing researches and writings such as magazines, books, journals, company websites, and research articles etc.

Chapter 3 this chapter discusses the research methodology that covers in detail the investigation paradigm, research method, and the strategy adopted in this research and collection of data. This chapter also deliberates, the types of data adopted in this particular research, different methods used for collecting the data, sampling size, the sampling design and the sampling plan, and in conclusion the techniques used to

investigate the collected research data and ethics followed in this research.

Chapter 4: The chapter intends to undertake a SWOT analysis to identify the Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats of Culinary tourism in Kerala. Then the TOWS matrix is formulated in view of developing strategies for Kerala Culinary Tourism, based on the SWOT analysis.

Chapter 5: This chapter gives a detailed explanation of the qualitative method of data collection. Structured interviews responses with Government officials, Tour operators and Tourists were thematically analyzed in this chapter.

Chapter 6: It deals with findings, suggestions and recommendations based on the study of the problems and prospects of Kerala Culinary Tourism. It also provides valuable insights for future researchers, investigators and academicians in this research topic.

9. Conclusion /Expected Outcome:

The study tries to highlight the existing scenario of Culinary tourism in Kerala. The study attempts to find a conceptual clarity for Kerala Culinary Tourism and also attempts to identify the problems of Culinary Tourism in Kerala that prevent the development of Culinary Tourism in Kerala.

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